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Bill Dobbins

Bill Dobbins is a pianist, composer, author and Professor of Jazz Studies and Contemporary Media at the Eastman School of Music. During his tenure there he has found time to direct the WDR Big Band in Cologne, Germany and the Netherlands Metropole Orchestra.

Bill was interviewed in Rochester, New York on January 11, 2012, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am off camera, but I'm happy to be in Rochester, New York at the Eastman School of Music talking to Professor Bill Dobbins. Thanks for joining me.

BD: Well thanks for inviting me, Monk.

MR: I hope my information is correct, but I found it really fascinating, I read when you were at Kent State there was no such thing as a jazz program there.

BD: Right.

MR: And here you are at one of the most prestigious music schools in the world, after a long tenure. That's quite a leap.

BD: Yes it is. It's quite a story also.

MR: How were you hired here? What credentials did you have? Because there was no jazz program to graduate from at the time, was there?

BD: Well it would probably be interesting to just take a few minutes to give a little bit of the background and the scene at Kent State at that time. When I started the program there, the jazz education programs that existed like at North Texas State and Berklee for example, those were really the exceptions. And most music schools in the early 1960s, jazz was a forbidden kind of thing. So at Kent State nobody wanted to have jazz and we had our problems with being kicked out of practice rooms and nobody wants to do anything, but students that started the same year that I did, we formed the first ongoing big band that they had there. And then when we got to the point where the band was pretty good they didn't have very much in the way of material at the time. The first set of Nestico/Basie charts had just come out, and there were some early Kenton things like some stuff from the "Cuban Fire" record, but very little stuff outside of stock arrangements for a big band. You can get just about anything today. So some of us started writing too because we needed the material to play. And when we got good enough where we thought we should invite a guest soloist, the person we decided to invite was Clark Terry. And that was an amazing association over the years. Clark has been a great mentor and friend. And we had such a great time with him that first year, and then before he was getting ready to go

back he said, "Well you have to invite me back next year, and next year I'll come back and bring Joe Williams with me." And we said, "Clark, I don't know if we can afford that, our budget is really small." He said, "Don't worry, I'll come for half as much."

MR: Oh my gosh.

BD: And so the next year he came back and brought Joe Williams. This was just a year or so after he had recorded that record with Thad Jones-Mel Lewis, with arrangements by Bob Brookmeyer and Thad. And so he brought all those arrangements with him. And we were in heaven.

MR: I'll bet.

BD: So I kept in touch with Clark over the years and they had these competitive festivals in those days that were sponsored by *DownBeat* magazine and some of the tobacco or liquor companies. They had regional festivals. And the amazing thing was that the winners in different categories, like big band, small group, soloist, composer/arranger, and so on, of these regional festivals. And they had all their expenses paid to go to a national festival. And we were a national finalist two or three years before I moved on from the Kent scene. And a couple of those years Clark was one of the judges, so we would see Clark again from time to time in our different activities as a band, and he was always very encouraging and helpful and friendly. And after I graduated from Kent with a bachelor's in classical piano and composition, a master's in composition, we moved to Cleveland in the summer of 1971. There was a great position there for a musician. There had been an entertainment show that originated from Cleveland through the sixties, by an entertainer-singer named Mike Douglas, "The Mike Douglas Show." And when the show moved to Philadelphia, the band leader for the show was a female pianist named Ellie Frankel. And when the show moved to Philadelphia they took her but she had to hire Philadelphia musicians. So the drummer from the Cleveland band, he took over this gig that she had, it was a six-night-a-week gig at this great restaurant and bar in downtown Cleveland, not far from the stadium called The Theatrical Restaurant. And the pianist that had been doing this, after she had left for a number of years, decided that he didn't want to do it anymore, so I ended up playing jazz six nights a week and getting paid pretty decent money for it, so we lived there from '71 to '73. And while we were at Kent there was a music critic that wrote for the Akron *Beacon Journal* named Ted Price. And he was a big fan of the big band at Kent State. In fact in 1969 in the little town of Kent — I think there are about 45 thousand people in the town and more than 20 thousand at the university — they have this little strip there. There was a restaurant/bar called Eddie's. And we convinced the guy that ran Eddie's to let the big band play there on Monday nights. And we made scale — 15 dollars a person. He charged a buck or two at the door, and between that and the meals and bar he made out okay. So we played there every Monday night for

a couple of years. And in ’69 we got an invitation to play at the Montreux Jazz Festival in Switzerland. And the music school wouldn’t help us at all as far as raising money, you know, they weren’t interested in that at all. So the people that came to hear us down at Eddie’s, they found out about this, and they were so incensed by it that a bunch of the businessmen who came down to hear the band, they organized a whole series of fundraising concerts, and raised all the money to send the band to Switzerland. It’s like something that you wouldn’t even believe would have happened. So Ted was also definitely a part of that. For some reason at one point this job opening came up with the Buffalo papers, and he moved from Akron to Buffalo. And of course it’s just an hour or so from Eastman, so he used to come here and hear concerts from time to time. He really fell in love with the Eastman Jazz Ensemble.

MR: Rayburn Wright.

BD: And I think it was about ’71, maybe ’72, no I think it was ’71, that Chuck Mangione, he had a really big commercial success with this record that he did with the Rochester Philharmonic called “Friends and Love.” And he had been teaching here as an instructor at the time that Ray came up from Radio City in New York and decided to move to Rochester and start a — well mostly a jazz writing curriculum. Chuck had been doing improvisation and they had a big band here, and so Ray came to do a whole sequence of writing courses. And around ’71 here when Chuck had this big success, he decided to go out and make a career for himself as a performer and end his teaching duties here. So the position opened up. And right around the time the position opened up, what usually happens in the searches, two of the people that Ray talked to, to see if they knew of anybody that they thought would be good for this job were this music critic, Ted Price, and he just happened to have as a guest soloist with the Eastman Jazz Ensemble right then, Clark Terry. So he asked both of these guys, you know, if they thought they knew anybody that would be good for this job. And both of them said right away, Bill Dobbins.

MR: The planets aligned for you. That’s interesting because now I was speculating, if you were to go on and do something else or retire or whatever, I think there’d be a lot of applicants for your position.

BD: Well I’m sure, yeah. I feel really fortunate that I was able to get this position at a time when having any kind of an advanced degree at all was fine. I don’t think I’d been here more than fifteen years when everything had already reached the point that people looking for any kind of serious job in college teaching, even if it was in a jazz program, a doctorate was expected.

MR: You know I had a similar experience at SUNY Fredonia in the music department. There was no jazz so to speak, but it was all student initiative. But there was something fantastic about that, that we were driven. We thought we were special.

BD: Well I often tell students now, I think that the greatest benefit is that, even actually when we went into the school before we even decided to try to develop this program, all the students that I could remember were my peers and my best friends at the time, we were so proactive — I guess maybe, I don't know if any of it had to do with the general social activism that was happening at the time — it was the period of the Civil Rights struggle and the Vietnam war and all of that. But my friends and I, if there was something that we felt was really indispensible to have in the school, we didn't wait around for somebody to do it for us, you know, we just started doing it ourselves. And even in terms of teaching and thinking about improvising and chord scale relationships and technical aspects of jazz playing, there were some of the guys in the band that didn't really have any experience in improvising but they really loved the music and were willing to learn. So I think about my junior year there I had already done a lot of transcribing of solos by different instruments and different styles. I wasn't into much early jazz at the time, I developed an appreciation for that after I came here and put together a jazz history course. But at least at that time I'd checked out a lot of things, at least from the bebop era up until what was going on at the time, which was Miles' band with Ron Carter and Tony Williams and Herbie Hancock and all of that. And every Saturday for a couple of hours in the afternoon the guys in the band would come over to our apartment and we'd have a kind of informal improvisation thing. We'd check out some solos that I had transcribed and people had questions about well why did they play this here, you know, about thematic development and improvised solos and chord scale relationships and things like that.

MR: So your education in jazz was mostly your own initiative?

BD: Yeah.

MR: When you got here you had to figure out how to put your knowledge into something that you could teach more than one-on-one too, in a classroom situation. That was sort of new ground at the time I would guess.

BD: It really was, yeah. It took a fairly long period of six months to a year of really thinking back and asking myself well how did I learn to do this, and what records or what players did I listen to to develop this kind of technique or this way of playing and this approach to harmony, where did I learn this way of the rhythm section working together that was a little more conversational and not so style specific. So it was a really great learning experience for me. One of the people that was really helpful in that, who actually became — he used to write reviews and articles for *Down Beat* magazine back in the 50s and 60s — unfortunately he died not too long ago, he became pretty well known as a cartoonist actually, a guy named Harvey Pekar. And he was a good friend of a flute player that I used to play with in Cleveland and who has since written a very well known book on jazz

history. It's called *Jazz Styles*, it's Mark Gridley. And when I knew I was going to have to put a jazz history course together there were so many deficiencies in my background of things that I didn't know about, so I called Harvey, and he graciously gave up a lot of his time. I think I went over there for three or four Saturdays for four or five hours. And he had a huge record collection. There was a room in his apartment about a fourth of the size of this room that was just floor to ceiling shelves. And he knew everything that was in there, even though he was not a musician he was very knowledgeable. So I just started thinking of topics off the top of my head, like Chicago jazz, and he went right to the Beiderbecke-Trumbauer, and this and that, and John Kirby, which is a little offshoot and some of that stuff thrown in. New Orleans jazz he knew exactly the stuff. "Oh yeah, I recently got interested in Lennie Tristano" you know, so right away the record would line up "East 32nd Street" and the new Tristano, the solo record where he's walking bass lines, big band, you know, Ellington in the 30s and 40s. And I think over that period of a month or two he put together a box of what at that time was reel to reel tapes, so I must have had twelve or fifteen 60 or 70 minute tapes. And that allowed me to put my jazz history course together.

MR: Do you think there's a difference in what you did back then as — I mean you were a student of the music, even while you were teaching. And you had to go to these lengths of what you just described. Nowadays everything's under your fingers and is available at a moment's notice, and I've been trying to figure out whether this is good or bad or both.

BD: Well I think it's like the Internet, it's both. It can save you a lot of time, but unfortunately it can only save you a lot of time if you know what you're looking for. If you don't know what you're looking for you will probably waste more time than any people in the past just going through a lot of stuff that's completely useless and it's not about the music at all. And that's the problem. I think today the most important thing, the most useful thing a good jazz instructor could do for a student is, well first of all to give them a capsule version in terms of recordings and artists and specific pieces of music of what some of the most important jazz recordings are to understand what jazz really is. Because I think one of the problems in recent years has been the NAMM jazz has been used to market so many kinds of music that don't have anything to do with jazz at all and it's just this kind of catchy marketing tool. And the most obvious one in recent years is so-called smooth jazz. And I remember in the early sixties, besides the fact that there were only four TV stations then and there was way more jazz and classical music and theater and opera and all kinds of stuff on those four channels than we can probably find on 150 channels on cable today. But in those days there were only a half a dozen categories of music. There was classical, jazz, pop and folk. That was about it. Then you had rhythm & blues. And

since then there's still one category for jazz basically, and there's about twenty categories for pop music. That's dumb and dumber.

MR: I was going to ask you about that. Because we've been talking about the 70s and I read your interview with your son, or part of it, and you specifically mentioned the 70s as a significant decade for the downfall of culture. I mean I'm paraphrasing you, but you had an attitude about that. And do you remember what specifically —

BD: Well I think a lot of what it has to do with is something that you can apply to so many areas today and that relates to everything from ecological crisis to medical and social issues and all kinds of things, the difference between organic and synthetic. And I think up until the explosion of technological media, which took place mostly after the mass marketing of television, pop music and music for most of the general public became more and more something that had not really developed in an organic way. It's something that was in a way being developed simply in order to sell as many units as possible. And if anybody would ask me the definition of commercial music, in the negative sense, that would be it — the music in which the sole purpose has to do with how many units can be sold, and nothing at all to do with the quality of the product. And the other thing too is that — well it's interesting that there are things that are related between this too, and actually things like the Federal Reserve. People who have studied like the history of the Federal Reserve know that was formed pretty much in secret by these really powerful bankers at this resort on Jekyll Island. And Gunther Schuller was here just a few months ago. He has a new biography that just came out, an autobiography that just came out. And he gave a kind of Q & A session with all the jazz students for an hour, which was really interesting. And one of the things he mentioned, that he actually experienced and was witness to was that sometime in the early 1960s the heads of the major television and radio corporations got together and had meetings, and actually decided, they made a conscious decision that from this point on the media — radio and television — are not going to be used to educate people. They would be used to sell things.

MR: Well you've said a few other things, not only about the 70s, but this is a leap to present day, but you sound fairly pessimistic about American culture in general, and especially having an experience in Germany and how they support the arts. And I liked this one thing. I think you were talking about the United States. You say, "You can afford a lot of worthwhile things if you're not trying to run the world."

BD: Yeah. But part of that running the world is actually part of, well the phenomenon that's happening now in our society, one of the unfortunate results of globalization, is this current economic crisis that we're in. And so even the phenomenon, the action of running the world so to speak is really connected to a value system that places value only on material things and money. So you have this really tiny number of people at the top,

people who control the banks internationally, and one of the reasons why running the world is very lucrative is because it takes money. And so that's one of the unfortunate things. I think part of this too, thinking about the proactivity of the students that I hung out with in my college days, I think that's one of the things that's diminished over the years. I think ironically at a time when we're probably closer to a really major global crisis than at any time since then, since that period in the 60s and 70s, it seems like people more and more, almost instinctively, just don't want to know what's going on. They don't want to know about what's happening.

MR: It's so ironic because everything is knowable.

BD: Yeah.

MR: I mean everything is gettable. But we don't want to know.

BD: Yeah. I was intrigued that just the other day I ran across a quote, Aldous Huxley said that — I can't remember the exact words but it was to the effect that the unfortunate thing about the ignorance of most people is that it's not simply the fact of not knowing, but it's that they don't want to know.

MR: Wow. Were you at Kent State in 1970?

BD: Yeah. I was there when all that happened. It was a very surreal kind of existence, to come to school and see tanks and soldiers with M-16s. You know it was a very unforgettable time.

MR: Were you on campus the day that massacre occurred?

BD: I was yeah. I wasn't actually there in the area where the people were shot but it wasn't all that far from the music building. And I can remember being there and hearing the gunfire. It was a terrible time. But it reminds me, I can't remember the exact person who said this, but it was one of the few real investigative reporters. It was somebody like Seymour Hersh or — well anyway — they mentioned that during the time before the Soviet Union fell that they were in Czechoslovakia and there happened to be a time when they were relatively certain that they were being surveilled with bugs in the room and they had some time to just talk to some of the people about what it was like to be in a country like that, where everything was so secret. And the power of the state was so complete. And they told them well in a way it's much easier for us than it probably is for you in America because here in Czechoslovakia we all know that everything that we hear on the radio or see on TV or read in the newspapers is basically lies, or a very selective version of the truth. But in America, Americans tend to believe that if it's on TV or on the radio or in the newspaper, it must be true.

MR: How do you encourage your students to be proactive?

BD: Well actually I tell a lot about things that I've gone through in my life. I mean this thing with the trip to Switzerland that the band made, and some of the things that I've gone

through with Clark Terry, and actually another connection with Clark too is when I got the job as music director for the WDR Big Band in Cologne, I arranged with a producer there at the first concert that I did with the band as the new director that Clark Terry would be a guest soloist. And so that was great too. And since I came back from Germany too, fortunately we were able to have Clark here a couple of times. He'd been here a couple of times before we left for Germany, and I made sure that he was here shortly after coming back, because he's not only such an amazing musician but that's another thing is that so many of the musicians that I was fortunate to come into contact with, black or white, it didn't matter if it was Joe Williams or Clark, or James Moody or people like Brookmeyer, Stan Kenton, and other people I got to know. That generation of musicians and before, there wasn't any black-white thing. And one of the things that's been disturbing to me in the last 30 or 40 years too is it seems to me like, especially in America, that the time when we really need to be just thinking about one race or one group of people, human beings, our society seems to be becoming more ghettoized than ever before. And I think that people are becoming separated in terms of religion, race and culture. And one of the things that was interesting, before we moved to Germany there were a couple of times when Todd Coolman and — I'm trying to think of the drummer — Billy Drummond — came a couple of times and did some rhythm section clinics for us and worked with bass players and drummers. And they told me some, unfortunately, believable stories, but sad, about how for example Cedar Walton's Eastern Rebellion Band and he had Bob Berg working in the band, that time and again club owners or even record producers would be telling Cedar, "How come you have a white tenor player?" And yeah. So this kind of stuff is, unfortunately, not dead.

MR: You know I think historians and sociologists and so forth who write about the music, they want it to be an issue more than it is. Because it's better copy.

BD: Oh yeah. And in relation to jazz education, one of the things that I deal with even with jazz majors let alone with people that are not musicians or that don't play jazz, is they still want to believe this myth that certain people are just anointed from above or that if you just ingest the right substance or hang out with the masters, you know, that this stuff is going to rub off. And they even sometimes fall prey to these myths because it's a more attractive story. It's the more fun thing to believe. It just takes a lot of hard work. One of the things that — I was fortunate to get it just a couple of years ago that I've been playing for my students at least once in every class, Gary Foster, who's been a good friend of mine for many years, I think he got these from Warne Marsh, one of the few recorded interviews with Charlie Parker. And there's one of them, my favorite, is an interview that Paul Desmond did with Charlie Parker for this radio show.

MR: I think I just saw it recently.

BD: Yeah. It's just amazing. And I mean one of the things that — well after listening to this one cut, Paul Desmond mentions that he noticed in the Parker solo that he quoted — used this pattern from the Klosé Etude book you know. And he said you know a lot of people think that this amazing facility that you have on the saxophone and this amazing facility with the language of improvisation and that's just something that you are born with and it's just sort of natural. He said — I heard this quote from the study and I was just wondering if you always did a lot of serious practicing. And then Parker says, very specifically he says, yeah from the time I was living at home and going to school, there was a period around the time that I was eleven, maybe six or seven years where I practiced ten, eleven hours a day. He said I practiced so much that the landlord was constantly threatening to evict us from the apartment. He said, "I was giving my mother problems." So Desmond said, "That's comforting to hear about it." It just wasn't done just with smoke and mirrors. He said, "No it wasn't done with smoke and mirrors, it was done with books."

MR: How do you try to recreate that, oh, musicians complain that there's no jam session scene anymore, there's not as much mentoring and all that. Is there a way to recreate that in academia?

BD: I think that's something that students really need to create for themselves, but I think one of the things, people talk about jam sessions, I think one of the things that students today don't realize is that in the old days when we had those sessions, even though it was mostly a cooperative atmosphere, it was also competitive. Not just competitive in a cut-throat sense, but there was also the attitude of respect for music and an understanding that, you know you'd go to a session, but if you're going to get up and play something, you should have something to play. And the session is not where you go to just play whatever comes out of the horn and then expect that by hanging around with these masters that are playing great stuff that some of that is going to rub off just because you logged a certain number of hours in the jam sessions. It's really the other way around. You're supposed to be doing your shedding on your own and putting your ideas together and getting to the point where you can play one or two or maybe three choruses on a tune that you know really well. So when you go to a jam session it's to — after other people have gotten up and said what they want to say in relation to that tune, you get up and say something. You don't just get up and meander and mumble and uh-uh-uh — I'm not going to be playing a solo, you know what I mean, on that tune, and I think the changes here are maybe in this bar it's sort of this, and no.

MR: I like — that was a good impersonation of I don't know what to do with my horn at this point.

BD: Yeah. The session is not, you don't get up and play in order to learn. You get up and play when you've put enough together on your own as a kind of rite of passage, a validation. Yeah, this person has something together now, they're ready to be a peer, a would-be, a wanna-be.

MR: Well said. One thing that's been floating around, not only on the Internet, but a question I've been asking the last couple of years, especially of sort of the mid-generation player, and it has to do with wrong notes. And the term by itself is a wrong term. I think you know what I mean. What constitutes a wrong note, in improvising?

BD: Well I think the clearest way to put it is that it's a note that doesn't relate to the chord and in the continuity of the music is not justified by resolution.

MR: By resolution.

BD: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

BD: There is no such thing as a wrong note. And I mean, well, let's see, in relation to — well one of the most basic things is people say don't play a major seventh on a dominant seventh chord. But if you play this [plays piano] it sounds pretty good to me. But what happens most of the time is that an inexperienced player will play that note [plays piano] and then just move away from it because they didn't really hear what that note implied. Really, improvising music is exactly like using a language. So using notes that clash with the chord they're not only not wrong but those are the most interesting parts of the music. Even classical composers did this all the time. Even Bach, Mozart, Chopin — you can find instances of major sevenths against dominant seventh chords. Like they're what classical theorists call non-harmonic tones, which literally means notes that don't belong in the harmony. And an essential part of real musicianship as an improviser or as a composer is the ability to use any note on the chromatic scale on any chord and make it sound believable. But the important thing is that, this is not an approach that's academic, it's an approach that comes from the music, from the aural tradition. It means that you need to listen enough to solos — well you need to be able to learn to sing as well — because the greatest early jazz soloists sang exactly the same way that they played their instruments. When Louis Armstrong sang, I mean he could sing anything he played, and he could play anything he sang. There are very few, even established jazz musicians today that can do that.

MR: Let me backtrack just a second though. If you said this is not something that has a place in academia, isn't the whole —

BD: Well what I meant is that it's not academic in the sense that, I mean the problem with classical music is that probably one of the reasons that improvisation died in classical music is that the theory became separated from the practice. So when Bach and the

Baroque composers were writing music and the music was contrapuntal, there was no system of harmony. People weren't thinking about chord progressions in Bach's time. All the Baroque music was composed and improvised in relation to melodic figures. And the composers and improvisers, first of all, everybody improvised then, because it was a part of the musical process, the musical common practice. And when Bach was writing inventions and fugues and things he wasn't hearing a chord progression, he was starting with a musical figure and by imitation and different basic techniques of thematic development — thematic development and putting these figures together — what counterpoint is is basically developing musical figures in different degrees of density and contrapuntal textures in ways that sound harmonious. And so what happened later on is that Ramos and some of the theorists, because they thought some of this music sounded so great, they tried to figure out why it sounded good. And that's when they came up with the basic theory of tonal harmony and common tone progressions. But what really makes counterpoint work, and what also makes the music that came after that that's differently textured, instead of contrapuntal lines you have a single note melody and chords that provide a kind of harmonic accompaniment. The difference between a Bach fugue and a Mozart or Beethoven sonata is that in both of those things it's primarily voice leading the principle, and the basic principle of voice leading that makes the music convincing. It's just that in counterpoint all the voices in the voice leading texture are independently melodic, whereas in a more so-called homophonic texture where you get a melody and a harmonic accompaniment the harmony has a simpler kind of counterpoint. It's basically half notes or whole notes working together. But just as the independent melodic counterpoint in Bach's music made sense, the individual layers of the harmony in homophonic accompaniment make sense because of the voice leading. And then there's also a more primary kind of voice leading that's the relationship between the primary melody and these voices of harmony underneath, and even more so with the bass line. One of the things that I tell my students, whether you're working on an arrangement for a group of horns or a big band, or whether you're learning a tune as a vehicle for improvisation, is first pay attention to the melody in the bass line. And even when you're doing a so-called re-harmonization, like one of the things I noticed when I started trying to transcribe things, whether it was pianists like Bill Evans or later on, one of my favorites, the biggest harmonic influence after Ellington and Strayhorn has been Clare Fischer. And both with Ellington and Strayhorn and Clare, when they arranged popular songs, standards from the American songbook, if you listen to the bass line that they use you will notice that it's not all that different from the bass line in the original sheet music. It's that what they fill that in with, between the melody and that bass line, or what they use as passing chords, in other words not just throwing out all the original chords and

saying I'm going to substitute chords for everything, almost invariably the essence of what the original bass line, or what the original progression was, is there. It's just that maybe instead of a six chord or a six nine chord for the tonic, they'll use a dominant seventh chord of some kind. Instead of a two minor chord, a two five, the two will be some kind of dominant seventh, a secondary dominant, or a half diminished, which is a little more colorful. And then they also find ways of using passing tones and inner voices that cause tension and give a really ordinary chord a different sound. And sometimes it's the placement of the notes. Like if you take a real basic sound like a minor ninth chord, usually the ninth is up here [plays piano] if it's in the melody. Or if it's not in the melody it'll be [plays piano] fairly far removed from the bass. And even if it's next to the [plays piano] maybe as a half step, it can kind of hide on you. But if you take a [plays piano] up here and put it in the bottom [plays piano] some people would say well that's wrong because of the same thing — all these rules that they have for harmony. You know, avoid minor ninths. But if you find, if you check out some of the greatest jazz music in terms of writing, you'll find minor ninths but it's just like with wrong notes in solos. It's where do those notes go. So for example [plays piano] and the resolution of this chord, this note also resolves [plays piano]. But it takes a real ordinary chord when you play it with this voicing, the same note in the melody, you hear this [plays piano]. But if you just take that same line and put it down here [plays piano], so contrary to what most people think, the art of harmonic substitution is not just in randomly changing chords, but it also has to do with finding different ways to voice the same chords that everybody uses to get different colors, depending on where the notes are. Two things in relation to this — I remember hearing a great radio show that Ben Sidran had — I don't know if it's still on — but he used to have a show called "Sidran on Record" where he interviewed all these jazz artists. And sometime, this must have been in the early 80s or so, not long before Gil passed, Gil Evans died — it was funny he had that kind of wild electric band, but he was on the show. And at one point Ben Sidran asked him what kind of things he was looking for and trying to develop in his music now. And he said, "Well I'm always looking for a different way to voice a dominant seventh chord."

MR: Lifelong learner.

BD: Yeah. So there's a great example. So the thing that I found with Clare and Duke is that a lot of times when I would find I'd hear this voice and go oh, what is that? Sometimes it would be something that I wouldn't think of playing, and sometimes I'd realize oh it's just the same voicing but the notes are rearranged so it gets a different color. We were talking about improvising and using a major seventh on a dominant chord, it's the same thing with writing. Like at the end of "Concerto for Cootie," after you hear the statement of the theme [plays piano], again he ends up on a D flat chord and it's in the key of F, so

he's on the flat sixth [plays piano]. And the clarinet's up here but with the alto. Cootie Williams plays the five-one, and the first thing you hear against this tonic note is G flat 7 [plays piano]. So that's not only a way of making a major seventh on a dominant seventh sound great, but it makes that F 6 chord that comes afterwards sound great too. Because it's not the chords that you use, it's how you get there and where you go from there. So one of the things I also try to impart to the students as much as possible, whether it's improvising or composing and arranging, that context is everything. And context, the simplest way I understand context is where I'm at, how did I get here, and where is this going? The place that you are, the thing immediately before that, and then what's going to follow it.

MR: You made me think of a question I was going to ask about being self-indulgent when you improvise.

BD: Yeah.

MR: And how do you deal with that. I mean do you notice it in your students sometimes and feel compelled to say something.

BD: A lot. I mean I not only notice it with students, I notice it in many, many professional musicians that have major record contracts and things too. Yeah, sure. And in fact one of the things that I find missing in music more and more — well one of the things I wanted to say too that's related to the ecology issue and some of the other important issues that are related to the planet even — is this idea about understanding what jazz is that has to do with a certain musical language. You hear, if you study languages, I studied French when I was in high school and college, and I was spending a lot of time in Spain in the 80s because French is really close to Spain and actually even easier in a lot of ways. I picked up Spanish really quickly and use it in classes and I'd use my French when I was doing stuff in French Canada in workshops and eventually in the 80s I got to spend regular time in France in Paris and Orléans. When we moved to Germany I did a lot of studying in German just on my own, because language was an interest. I'd been doing some workshops in Germany since about three or four years before we moved there. And I just thought well it would be nice even if I could just say a few things, you know, start picking up some of the language. And when we actually lived there it moved very quickly. But we speak American English — you don't hear this as much anymore because of — well one of the adverse effects of technology is that, especially with TV, the English language is getting flattened out, so that everybody speaks the same. And even in areas of the south and areas of the country with easily detectible accents, if you watch the news from different areas they're doing everything they can to flatten it out. The other thing we were talking about, organic music and synthetic music — another thing that's not only in pop music has melody and harmony and rhythm been pretty much

flattened out and dumbed down from a vocabulary of a couple of thousand words to fifty or sixty. But the expressive aspects of the music, which make it sound human, I mean the things that enable you to identify one player or one singer from another. Dynamics. Those things are all disappearing as well. So what did I start this out with? I lost the train of thought.

MR: We were talking about self-indulgence.

BD: Yeah. Okay. Yeah. Okay. So anyway, we speak the American English language and if we hear somebody speaking that language with an accent, if we're a student of the language if we really know it well we can identify the accent. Like in jazz there might be more of a blues accent sometimes. There might be more of a so-called cool accent in other players. There might be some players that in the course of their phrases they're constantly changing from reaching many different levels of volume, from the softest notes in the music to the loudest, and then other people that even though they're convincing soloists, their dynamic level is not so variable, and stays pretty much — even in Baroque music. I mean with the instruments that they had there is not a huge dynamic range. So if there's one element that doesn't have so much to offer in the music you have to make up for it by doing more with those other elements. But then we can also tell in a minute if somebody's an immigrant — speaking English with a foreign accent — or, either an immigrant or a native speaker, that just doesn't know the language very well and they're making lots of grammatical mistakes or speaking in fragments or speaking in a dissociative, almost schizophrenic way, leaping from one theme to another without any notice or any connection. And you can make an analogy between all these things and playing a jazz solo or writing a big band arrangement or a composition. And the thing that I think is the greatest danger for the music is when people get the idea that well why should I play swing music? You know, that's all been done. Louis Armstrong already did all that. Why should I play bebop? You know, Charlie Parker did all that. But no, that's not true at all. That's like saying that we have to invent a new language because everything has already been written in English that can be thought of. That's absolutely not the case. And everybody today still, if you want to be a poet or a short story writer or a playwright or a novelist or a social critic, philosopher, whatever, you're going to use American English. But the fact that everybody uses American English doesn't mean that it's impossible to eventually develop your own voice in the way that you use that language in the way you develop the subject matter that you want to discuss and go into. So I mean to me it would be a real tragedy because we're so interested in creating something new all the time. I mean it's mostly novelty for it's own sake from what I've found. And when we go back, especially when we listen to not only people that play in a fairly technical way, like Charlie Parker. I mean he's a great example of somebody that

sometimes played a lot of notes, but when you really painstakingly learn one of the Parker solos, you can hear that every one of those notes make sense, and that one phrase really has something to do with the phrase before or with the phrase that's coming afterwards. And very often the key notes in those phrases, the top note or the longest note, may even be the note that happens to be there in the original melody. But you have to get to more than just a completely superficial understanding of music before you start to recognize these things. But on the other hand, then there are people like, well Gerry Mulligan, for example, or Chet Baker, who use far less notes and play slightly different tone color. And in a certain way they're making solos not from the more technical vocabulary than Parker and Gillespie and Bud Powell evolved in the bebop era, but from melodic material that you associate with the riffs of swing tunes and with melodies from the American Popular Songbook. But the thing that both of those styles have and that they have in common with Louis Armstrong or any meaningful jazz that's happened in the last fifty years is that there is a real logic and integrity within the soloing, just like a nice short story or a poem. It has a clear beginning, middle and end, and once you hear what the soloist has to say in that first phrase, if you pay attention everything that comes after that has something to do with what came before.

MR: That's interesting because on the way down here I was listening to WGMC and Sonny Rollins was playing "Blue Room."

BD: Yeah.

MR: I almost had to stop the car. It was so perfect. And when he got to, I don't know, bar five, and the [scats] every time he played that it was like ah, I could never think of that.

BD: Yeah.

MR: The emphasis and the tone, it was brilliant. And the whole thing, he almost set the tone for the rest of his solo. It was just really cool.

BD: Well I mean one of the things that I'm reminded of just as we're sitting here talking, and I'm also trying to impress on the students, because it doesn't have directly anything to do with jazz at all, but the relative degree of difficulty of just extraneous, spontaneous speaking, public speaking, just even having conversation like what we're doing now, and not necessarily feeling that we have to keep the words going when we're trying to think of the next thing, we don't habitually invade the silence with uh, uh, uh, let me see I think uh, uh, uh. And how many people that are doing the news on the national networks, or how many of our politicians or people who are corporate heads or whatever, how many of those people could actually sit down even for a minute or two and express themselves verbally in a concise way without stammering.

MR: Right. Or without a teleprompter.

BD: Yeah, yeah. And yet I mean this is a great analogy and a great illustration too. Because improvising a jazz solo that makes sense is no different from what we're trying to do right now, making statements about a particular kind of music that we love, and trying to do it in a way that we say exactly what we intend to say right now, and not just anything that comes into our mind to fill up the space because we're nervous.

MR: Right.

BD: Nervous of silence. That's another phenomenon also I think more of our time too because we're surrounded with so much extraneous noise all the time. Because every time you go into a restaurant or a shopping mall or anywhere, some kind of music or noise is ubiquitous. And because of that, even the very idea that there is, or could be, an inner life, which is my real life — I mean that's where the action is all the time, whether I'm looking at you or looking out the window here, or listening to a piece of music, or having a conversation with my wife or whatever it is, even though it's all happening out there, the experience and interpretation and mediation of that, if there is any, it all has to happen in here. One of the most profound books that I think I've read maybe in my life actually is a book by Ken Wilber, a really extraordinary American philosopher, called *A Brief History of Everything*. And two of the things that I found extraordinarily useful in this book — I think he wrote it around '89, late 80s or early 90s — one is that the evolutionary process — and this is an idea also that was explored a little bit by Arthur Koestler, a really brilliant novelist and humanist and writer who was born in Budapest and grew up and was educated in England. He died I think in the late 60s or early 70s. But in one of his books — I can't remember if it's *The Act of Creation* or *The Sleepwalkers*. He wrote a trilogy of books — *The Sleepwalkers, The Act of Creation,* and *The Ghost in the Machine*. *The Sleepwalkers* is history of science in the time of the Greeks or before, up to Isaac Newton. And it's called *The Sleepwalkers* because of the faulty nature in which these men came upon these different things and even the reluctance because of the censorship of the church and government agencies to even let out new realizations once they were made, because you could die for it. Like Oscar Wilde said if you tell people the truth you'd better be able to make them laugh or they will kill you. And the second book, *The Act of Creation* is, he makes a lot of interesting analogies between creativity in the arts and on the one hand, on the sublime end, the life of the mystic and the inner life, and on the other end the humor end, because creativity has to do with the ability to notice and make use of the intersections of two different planes of existence or two different ways of looking at the same thing. And in humor that's where the joke comes from. But of course that same phenomenon happens in terms of — for lack of a better term — spiritual experience — our experience of the world that we can't see, which is for you and I probably the most important stuff you know. Or in the arts, the

same thing. And in one of those books, I think it was the one on science, he was one of the first people to start using this term "holon" H-O-L-O-N which is the concept of how the universe is really put together, because since we've become aware that just as there is an infinity from the cell up to the whole cosmos, there is one in the other direction too, that the subatomic particles and on and on and on and on. So it goes to infinity both ways. But in that chain, each thing is both — each thing that has evolved has both transcended and included the previous thing. And it also becomes something that's transcended and included by the next thing. So the key concepts are transcend and also include. And the other interesting aspect of that is that at any point in that chain if something goes wrong with a whole on a particular level, then everything that exists above that whole on the chain disappears eventually in time, is doomed, while everything that's below that whole stays intact. Interesting concept, you know, because it relates to everything. So in music, people have this concept of whether it's jazz or so-called classical music or pop music or whatever it is, that it has to be new all the time. But the thing that's key, when I think of somebody like Clare Fischer or Ellington or even Bach, one of the things with Bach, back in Bach's own time, Bach was not considered to be that important. He was not an innovator. That was not the key thing for him. He was a consolidator. And that was his greatness. Because he was able to understand the ways that different people in different European countries were working with this music that was going on, and get to the point where he actually understood it and could do it better than them or as good as them. In the suites he had to do it in the manner of composition in the manner of dance forms etcetera, you know, that people were using in England. I mean when we listen to it today we don't hear all that much difference because it's that Baroque stuff. But if you really get into it, you know I'm not an expert, there are really people who are experts at Baroque music, they could tell you exactly in the English suites what's the stuff that is unique to the English suites and why that's typically what they were doing in England at the time, where the French suites the same way, or the Italian concerto. And the same thing with Ellington. The thing that was unique about Ellington's orchestra was that it was the only big band I think that's ever existed where every time you heard Ellington's orchestra you heard the whole history of jazz. Because he didn't just stop playing pieces that he wrote that were really great pieces in the late 20s and early 30s, but you know, they evolved because new people came in to take over those roles. And in many instances they didn't even play notes in the solos that were that different from the predecessor. You know, sometimes Lawrence Brown would actually play a Tricky Sam solo. Or sometimes Cootie Williams would play a solo that some earlier plunger player who might have been a better trombone plunger player. But the way they played it, and the way the rhythm section played the stuff, you've got not only the newest pieces that he was writing that

sounded as modern as anything anybody was doing, but first of all they always sounded like jazz because they had the jazz beat. And then they also sounded like jazz because they also had this incredible mixture of the chromatic tonal harmony that you hear in European music from around the time of Bach through at least the Russian composers who still had ties with tonality whether it was in an obvious way like with Rachmaninoff or a less obvious way like with Shostakovich and Prokofiev or early Stravinsky, there was still a definite tie with tonality that was colored and filtered but it still was in the key and you could still hear it when you were on the way somewhere and then you would arrive there, you know. And so to me that's a great correspondence to this idea in Wilber's book of transcending and including. And the same thing with somebody like Clare Fischer. You hear, he could play, well yeah, there's a blues that he wrote, this is another good example of the so-called wrong note stuff too, but you can find this stuff in Ellington and Strayhorn's work, and Brookmeyer, any of the best jazz composers. I bought this record of Clare's when I was in high school. It came out in '63. It was called "Extension." He did a record for Dizzy Gillespie around 1960 or '61 called "Portrait of Duke Ellington" where he experimented with a different kind of big band. It was a big band with no trumpets. And I'm not sure if he didn't use trumpets because Dizzy was going to be the soloist, or if it was just a novel reason. But it was saxophones with lots of woodwinds, from flute down to bass clarinet, and the brass section instead of trombones and trumpets it was three French horns, one trombone, one bass trombone and one tuba. It was the six brass, and then piano, bass and drums. Well a couple of years later he put out this record on the Pacific label called "Extension." And it was a similar instrumentation only there was sometimes six saxophones in some of the pieces, and he added an organ. Instead of using it like a Jimmy Smith kind of jazz organ thing, he actually used it like an extra reed section. And then vibes as well as piano and organ. And it's one of the most amazing recordings of original jazz compositions that I've heard that were really connected to the traditions. This main title tune, "Extensions," there is two themes. The first one is a blues. When I first got this record, in '63, I mean my early background is classical piano lessons from the time I was nine through the end of my master's degree. And I discovered jazz — this is another thing — I discovered jazz totally by accident. I was at a friend's house in high school. My father was a Pentecostal minister so he didn't want me anywhere near jazz. So when I was in high school I couldn't be in the jazz band but I could accompany the chorus. So there was this guy in the chorus that — we used to hang out after school — and his father was a jazz fan. And this is interesting too, because this guy was not a musician per se. I mean he could read music to a certain extent, but he was not a virtuoso pianist. But this was in the earliest days of rock & roll, which was really rhythm & blues influenced, like Fats Domino, Jerry

Lee Lewis, Little Richard and that kind of stuff. And he had an upright piano in the house. That's another thing that I read that's an interesting, worthwhile point too that at the turn of the twentieth century the biggest disseminator of music in America was the piano. So that shows you, you know, people today just push a button and it all just happens for them. We'd get back to his place and sometimes he could actually sit down and play the chorus of the rhythm & blues or boogie woogie piano from his Jerry Lee Lewis record that he had figured out from the record. But his father was a jazz fan and when I was over there one day he played me some records by the Modern Jazz Quartet and Ahmad Jamal's trio with Vernell Fournier and Israel Crosby And Errol Garner's "Concert by the Sea." And Dave Brubeck, well the "Time Out" records but also the "Gone with the Wind" where they play all these songs associated with the south, it's still one of my favorite records. And I just heard immediately that these people were using all this great chromatic harmony that I loved in classical music and impressionism, and even the Russians again. But they were using it in a conversational way, like a language you know. And from the first time I heard that I had to figure out, how do they do that? So it was not long after that that I got this "Extension" record and as soon as I heard this it just — like I've got to figure out what's going on. I've never heard anything like this. I had heard the Thad Jones and Mel Lewis things and I'd heard some Basie and Ellington and Kenton, Maynard Ferguson's early 60s stuff, Woody Herman. I sat down and some of the harmonies were so unusual that I sometimes couldn't, wasn't even sure exactly is that bass note a G or an A flat? Because I don't have perfect pitch. I put this record on a reel to reel tape and I just couldn't figure it out. And so I developed a kind of program of ear training for myself where I would take records I really liked with two horns, three horns, four horns, small horn sections, Horace Silver, the Blakey stuff with Freddie Hubbard and Wayne Shorter and Curtis Fuller, and some of the Gerry Mulligan Sextet. He did a couple of records with the sextet, and some of Duke's things of small groups, and try to figure this stuff out by following the line of each individual horn, you know? And every year or so I'd come back to this record to see if I could get any closer. It was so frustrating. And later on even, when the cassette players came out and you had little portable cassettes. When I was living here I was doing some gigs with Nick Brignola in the mid-80s — no it was in the early 80s — no it must have been the late 70s actually, because I got that record of Clare's around '65 or '66. So it must have been around '75. We were doing some concerts downstate. They put us up in hotels and so everywhere I went during this period I took my portable cassette player and I would be listening to this record all the time. Finally one night when we were back from a gig I realized that this melody, the notes directly above the bass, it was just basic dominant seventh chords, with roots, thirds and sevenths [plays piano]. But because it didn't seem related to the melody

it was I guess one of the things that threw me off. Because the melody is real simple too. It's a B flat blues and has lots of minor thirds [plays piano], then it goes to the four [plays piano], and then to one [plays piano] and then to five [plays piano] and then one again before it hits the tonic, which has the fifth in the melody or no, the third in the melody [plays piano]. That's how it ends. But when I tried to put that melody with the chords, one of the things that started giving me trouble was when I put the melody with the chords it didn't seem to work [plays piano]. Especially with this chord [plays piano]. [inaudible] it was the saxophones, it was that second voice that made everything work [plays piano]. Now that's unresolved, but listen to what happens at the end of the next phrase [inaudible]. Then it resolves [plays piano]. And along the way you've got all these things. It starts with a G7, with the 4th in the melody, against the 3rd. With that A flat it softens them both because it makes consonant intervals. A major 6th, a major 3rd. It's just enough to — and the next chord is C7 but it's got this note [plays piano]. Once again, you know, you've got this consonance that's taking some of your attention away from that. And eventually when you get to the end of the phrase [plays piano] it gets to the third. This voice — not yet, but the next time you get there [plays piano]. So that's this thing I was talking about before, of that real musicians that really hear music as language, the way other people use words but in relation to a really specific language, when they introduce a dissonance, whether it's in the melody or in an inner voice in the harmony, it's there for a reason. And if you listen to it and pay attention to it, you'll eventually hear why they did that. Because it ends up going there.

MR: There's a whole lesson there for arrangers and composers.

BD: Yeah. And the thing that relates to improvising then is I started realizing like if you take, one of the things that Clare uses actually comes from —

MR: I have to tell you we're about to run out of tape. But we'll have to do part 2.

BD: Yeah.

MR: I mean it's been really fascinating for me.

BD: Where are we at, a minute left?

MR: Yeah, we've got like two minutes left.

BD: Okay well let me just say at the end that all this stuff comes from different places. In Clare's music, I mean in Ellington and Strayhorn got a lot stuff from classical composers but they were very secretive about it because they were never answered any questions about it directly because it was better for their careers to keep that mystique on, by answering questions and by not answering them. But Clare, it was great getting to know him because all the things that people say, oh that's Clare Fischer, he can tell you where he got every one of those things.

MR: Okay.

BD: So one of the things that he uses is in dominant seventh cords, like if you were in B flat 7 going to E flat, if you have a B flat altered chord with a raised ninth in the melody [plays piano] it will result in E flat. Some of the other things he does sometimes is instead of starting directly with a dominant seventh [plays piano] he'll use the major seventh. It's a nonharmonic tone. And what that relates to in terms of bebop music is the tritone in there. Because the note that makes the four-three suspension in an E 7 chord, A to G#, in the tritone the B flat 7 in that same line is the major seventh to the minor seventh [plays piano]. So when you play this on an E 7 chord it sounds perfectly — everybody does that. But instead of E 7 going to A, if it's B flat 7 going to E flat, you use the same upper voices.

MR: Beautiful.

BD: Yeah. Some of this is also in Shostakovich's First Symphony where he does a lot of things where he has a flat 9 in the melody and he not only uses that major 7th, but uses the lowered 5th next to the 3rd. So you get this major second inside too.

MR: Well thank you for the master class, in addition to the interview. It's been a great pleasure.

BD: Well the pleasure was mine.

MR: This is really fascinating stuff and I'll have to come back and continue this conversation.

BD: Yeah, I'd love to do a second part. I think one of the great things to get into would be not only things from later, what I think of as really grounded, legitimate jazz styles in the sense that Ken Wilber would talk about — developments that would come along which not only would transcend what came before, but would still include the essence of everything that came before, both in relation to jazz and how many jazz musicians, some of the most creative, have taken things from classical musicians, classical composers particularly, twentieth century composers, and use them in a jazz context.

MR: All right. I'll look forward to it.

BD: Great.

MR: Thank you.

BD: You're welcome.